Cleveland Clinic

Food Poisoning

Food poisoning can happen to anyone who swallows food or water that's contaminated by germs. Most people recover in a day or two without treatment. But some can become seriously ill — especially those with weaker immune systems. Children under 5 and people over 65 are also more at risk of dehydration.

What Is Food Poisoning?

Video content: This video is available to watch online.

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Learn the difference between the stomach flu and food poisoning.

Food poisoning happens when you swallow food or water that's contaminated by germs or other toxins. Your body acts to remove the toxins from your digestive tract through vomiting or diarrhea, or both. This may go on for a day or two. The symptoms of food poisoning are your body's way of working to return to health. It's not pleasant, but it usually works. Rest up, and you should feel better soon.

Symptoms and Causes

Food poisoning symptoms

Symptoms of food poisoning can include:

- Diarrhea
- Fever
- Headache
- Nausea
- Stomach pain
- Vomiting

Signs of food poisoning can kick in within two to six hours after you ingest contaminated food or liquids. But it depends on the germ you get. Some types need more time in your body before they become harmful. Symptoms tend to go away quickly, too. They typically last 12 to 48 hours. The food poisoning timeline is generally quicker than many other common illnesses. Though, it may not feel like it at the time.

Food poisoning causes

The most common causes of food poisoning are bacteria. Bacteria can grow in food when it isn't:

- Fresh
- Washed or filtered
- Handled in a sanitary way
- Cooked to a safe internal temperature

- Refrigerated or frozen promptly
- Kept at proper temperatures

Other germs, like viruses, parasites and fungi, can also poison your food. They might live in the environment where your food or water comes from. Or they might transfer to your food from somebody who handles it, if that person is infected. Food poisoning happens everywhere. But it's especially easy to get it when traveling abroad. This is sometimes called traveler's diarrhea.

Common food poisoning infections

There are more than 250 specific types of food poisoning. Some of the most common causes include:

- ***Salmonella***: This is the most common cause of food poisoning in the U.S. It also causes the most hospitalizations and deaths. Raw eggs and undercooked poultry are common sources.
- ***E. coli***: *E. coli* bacteria don't always cause illness. But some strains produce a toxin that irritates your small intestine. These are often found in undercooked meat and raw vegetables.
- ***Listeria***: These bacteria can live in soft cheeses, raw sprouts, deli meats and hot dogs. *Listeria* infection (listeriosis) can be especially dangerous during pregnancy.
- **Norovirus**: You can get norovirus by eating undercooked shellfish, leafy greens or fresh fruits. You can also get it from a sick person. This virus is a common cause of stomach flu.
- **Hepatitis A**: The hepatitis A virus can infect shellfish, fresh produce or water and ice contaminated by poop. Like other viral hepatitis infections, it can be hard on your liver.
- ***Staphylococcus***: A staph infection can occur when the bacteria transfer from an infected person to food they handle. Especially if they're touching meats and dairy products. It can affect many parts of your body.
- ***Campylobacter***: This common bacterial infection produces severe symptoms. You might be sick for weeks. Common sources include undercooked poultry, contaminated vegetables and raw milk.
- ***Shigella***: *Shigella* is often found in cream- or mayonnaise-based salads, like tuna, potato, macaroni or chicken. It can cause blood or mucus in your diarrhea (bacillary dysentery).

Is food poisoning contagious?

Infections that spread through food poisoning are contagious. When you're infected, you can spread germs through tiny particles of vomit or poop. These particles can linger on surfaces or on your fingers. They can transfer to another person if they touch those surfaces, or if you touch their food. Food poisoning infections can spread fast in close quarters. They often spread in schools and cruise ships.

Food poisoning risk factors

Anyone can get food poisoning. But some people are more likely to get sick from food poisoning than others. It partly depends on how much of the toxin you ingest. Your overall health also plays a role.

Even with sanitary food handling practices, there's usually a small amount of germs in your food. Your immune system fends off minor infections like these all the time, without you even knowing about it. When your immune system gets overloaded, that's when the toxins in your food become "poisonous." This means your body has to produce a bigger reaction to remove the germ or toxin.

You may be more likely to get sick from food poisoning — or have a more severe reaction to it — if your immune system isn't as strong as average. Many things can impact your immunity, including:

- **Age**: Children under the age of 5 have immature immune systems. Mature immune systems begin to decline after the age of 65.
- **Pregnancy**: Pregnancy is demanding on your body, leaving you with fewer resources than usual to fight off infections.
- **Chronic illnesses**: Many chronic conditions can affect your immunity. Infections, cancer, immunodeficiency diseases and autoimmune diseases are a few.

- **Medications**: Corticosteroids and immunosuppressants can repress your immune system. This makes it easier for you to catch germs.

Food poisoning complications

Complications from food poisoning are rare. But they can be severe and, sometimes, even fatal. Severe dehydration is the most common complication. You lose a lot of water and electrolytes with frequent vomiting and diarrhea. And it can be hard to drink enough fluids to replace them. Some of the infections that you can get through food poisoning can also cause other complications. These can include:

- **Miscarriage and stillbirth**: *Listeria* infection is especially dangerous for growing fetuses. The bacteria can cause neurological damage and even death.
- **Kidney damage**: *E. coli* can lead to hemolytic uremic syndrome (HUS) and kidney failure.
- **Arthritis**: *Salmonella* and *campylobacter* bacteria can cause chronic arthritis and joint damage.
- **Nervous system and brain damage**: Some bacteria or viruses can cause a brain infection called meningitis. Others can cause a neurological disorder called Guillain-Barré syndrome.

Diagnosis and Tests

How doctors diagnose food poisoning

Your healthcare provider may suspect food poisoning based on your symptoms. They might ask you about what you've recently eaten to try and identify the source of the toxin. If you have certain symptoms, they may want to check for specific parasites or bacteria. They might take a poop sample or give you a blood test. But often, they don't need to know the type of germ you have.

Management and Treatment

What is the treatment for food poisoning?

In most cases, you can manage food poisoning at home. Staying hydrated is the most important thing you can do to support your body while it does its work. Supportive care might include a hydration formula, like Pedialyte™. This can help to balance your electrolytes and prevent dehydration. If you or your child shows signs of dehydration, you might need to go to the hospital for IV fluids.

Is there a medication for food poisoning?

Certain types of infections may need treatment with antibiotics or antiparasitic medications. Your healthcare provider can tell you if you have one of these types. Most of the time, antibiotics won't help. And in some cases, they can make food poisoning worse.

Healthcare providers don't prescribe medications to stop diarrhea if you have food poisoning. This is because they can make it last longer. But you can try over-the-counter (OTC) bismuth subsalicylate (Pepto Bismol®). This might help relieve your symptoms.

When should I call my healthcare provider about food poisoning?

Call your healthcare provider if you're pregnant or breastfeeding with food poisoning. Call if you're caring for a child under 5 or a person over 65 who's having trouble keeping fluids down. People in these age groups are more at risk of dehydration. Call if you or your child has any unusual symptoms, like:

- Persistent, high fever of over 102 degrees Fahrenheit (38.9 degrees Celsius)
- Bloody diarrhea or bloody vomit
- Dark pee or lack of pee
- Blurred vision
- Delirium or confusion

- Dizziness or lightheadedness

Outlook / Prognosis

What should I expect if I have food poisoning?

Most people recover in a few days without any treatment. But if you or someone in your care has an unusually severe reaction, you might need medical help. The most common reason for this is dehydration, especially in those who are under 5, over 65, pregnant or have weaker immune systems.

Prevention

How can food poisoning be prevented?

Safe food handling practices are the most important way to prevent food poisoning. Those who harvest, handle and prepare food need to be alert to the risks at every stage of the process.

Safe practices include:

- **Cleaning**: Wash raw produce well in clean water. Wash your hands and utensils before using them. Clean and disinfect all surfaces that your food will touch. That includes cutting boards, countertops and plates. Don't forget things your hands might touch in the kitchen, like towels.
- **Separating**: Keep raw meat and eggs away from produce. Cooking kills germs on meat — but if those germs touch uncooked food, they can spread.
- **Cooking**: Cook meats and seafood thoroughly to the proper temperatures to kill germs. Whole cuts of meat can be pink on the inside if they're well-seared on the outside. Ground meats need to be thoroughly cooked with no pink left. Fish should be flakey and opaque, not translucent.
- **Chilling**: Refrigerate or freeze prepared foods within two hours of cooking. This keeps bacteria from growing. Sauces like gravy and mayonnaise need to be kept cool while they're out. Check the expiration dates on your refrigerated foods and look for signs of mold or an "off" smell.

A note from Cleveland Clinic

You probably feel awful right now. Diarrhea, vomiting, fever. These symptoms mean your body is trying to purge the toxin that has taken over your digestive system. The good news is that food poisoning usually runs its course in a day or two. Just focus on staying hydrated and letting your body fight it off. If your symptoms don't get better soon, or they get worse, check in with your healthcare provider.

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References

Cleveland Clinic's health articles are based on evidence-backed information and review by medical professionals to ensure accuracy, reliability and up-to-date clinical standards.

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